“My marriage will never get better.”

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Where it often comes from

Repeated arguments, broken promises, betrayal, or years of feeling alone can make hopelessness understandable. You may have tried hard without seeing lasting change. Depression, exhaustion, or memories of an unhappy family can make the future look like a fixed continuation of the past.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture offers hope and practical guidance without promising that every marriage will recover. A gentle answer, careful listening, and truthful action can change some patterns. You can work on your part, ask for help, and look for sustained evidence of change. You cannot make your spouse become willing, honest, or safe. Hope means remaining open to what can change while facing what is happening now; it does not require ignoring ongoing harm.

> *“If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone”* (Romans 12:18).

Also see

> “A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger” (Proverbs 15:1).

> “He who answers a matter before he hears it— this is folly and disgrace to him” (Proverbs 18:13).

> “Let your gentleness be apparent to all. The Lord is near” (Philippians 4:5).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

Common self-statements

- Nothing we try will matter.
- We had another argument, so we have made no progress.
- The past proves the future is hopeless.
- If change were possible, it would have happened already.
- I have to fix the marriage by myself.
- Seeking help would only confirm that we have failed.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Treating a feared future as a settled fact.
- Overgeneralization: Turning repeated disappointments into an absolute prediction.
- Discounting change: Dismissing small, sustained improvements because everything is not solved.
- Excess responsibility: Assuming one person can repair a two-person relationship.

Challenging questions

- What evidence supports my fear, and what evidence would show even a small change?
- Have we tried a different approach consistently, rather than repeating the same argument?
- What is within my influence, and what belongs to my spouse?
- Is there willingness, accountability, and follow-through from both of us?
- Would private professional guidance help me assess our options?

• Can I choose a wise next step without predicting the entire future?

Truth summary

> I do not know that my marriage will never improve. Some patterns may change with willingness, practice, accountability, and appropriate help. I can take a wise step and observe what happens. Improvement is not guaranteed, and I am not responsible for making my spouse change. My life can still contain support, purpose, and hope.

Selected Scripture references draw on Pearls, "Marriage" (pp. 240–241) and "Marriage Guidance" (pp. 242–244), with other passages selected for this belief. Quotations use the BSB.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Marriage
- Marriage Guidance
- Hopeless
- Guidance
- Peace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Marriage

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Glorious Unfolding — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's story continues beyond a painful or confusing chapter.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Even If — MercyMe
Trust in God need not depend on receiving the particular miracle we want.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My marriage will never get better"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My marriage will never get better." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What small change would I recognize?
- ☐ What have we tried consistently?
- ☐ What can I influence?
- ☐ Is there mutual willingness and follow-through?
- ☐ What help would support a wise decision?
- ☐ What is my next step, rather than my final prediction?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ The future is uncertain, rather than already decided.
- ☐ One argument does not measure every part of our progress.
- ☐ I can evaluate consistent actions instead of promises alone.
- ☐ I am responsible for my choices, not my spouse's choices.
- ☐ Getting help can be a constructive next step.
- ☐ My well-being matters even while the marriage is uncertain.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 12:18
  "If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone."
- ☐ Proverbs 15:1
  "A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger."
- ☐ Proverbs 18:13
  "He who answers a matter before he hears it— this is folly and disgrace to him."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Small-change record: Define one observable change, record whether it occurs, and note whether it lasts. Record setbacks as well as improvement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  A personal reminder based on James 1:19: "Sarah can practice being quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to anger."
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Marriage Guidance" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose exercises you can do safely. If there is coercion, violence, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying joint exercises.

- [ ] Choose one low-conflict pattern to change. For one week, try a calm greeting or a brief practical check-in. Predict the result first, then record what actually happens.
- [ ] Define what improvement would look like. Replace "everything must be better" with one measurable sign, such as taking turns speaking for five minutes without insults.
- [ ] Seek a private consultation. Discuss your concerns and whether joint counseling is appropriate. If you fear retaliation, seek private support before proposing joint exercises.
- [ ] Review the week's evidence. List helpful behavior, unchanged problems, and harmful behavior separately. Do not count promises as completed change.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My marriage will never get better": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One observable change or setback
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My marriage will never get better.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

God of hope, meet me in my disappointment. Give me courage to face the truth, wisdom about the next step, and strength to seek help. Keep me from both hopeless certainty and false promises. Help me remember that my life matters to You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.